

MINI-COURSE BLUEPRINT · 2026

Trauma-Informed *Care* in Customer- Facing Roles

A Foundational Learning Experience

DESIGNER

Joy Kim

ROLE

Instructional Designer

MODALITY

Blended / eLearning

This blueprint outlines a foundational course that equips customer-facing employees to recognize, respond to, and support customers who may be experiencing stress or trauma — building confidence, empathy, and practical de-escalation skills grounded in the **3 R's framework**.

The case for *trauma-informed* service.

Frontline employees regularly encounter customers in distress, but most receive little guidance on what's happening beneath the surface — or how to respond in a way that de-escalates rather than inflames.

The Challenge

Many customer-facing employees are **not familiar with how to use trauma-informed strategies** in their daily interactions. When a customer arrives anxious, angry, or shut down, an untrained response can unintentionally escalate the situation or re-traumatize the customer. This course closes that gap by translating the science of stress and trauma into concrete, repeatable communication behaviors.

Project Snapshot

AUDIENCE

Customer-facing employees across frontline, support & intake roles

MODALITY

Blended — eLearning with live practice options

CORE FRAMEWORK

The 3 R's: Recognize, Respond, Resist re-traumatization

ESTIMATED SEAT TIME

45–60 minutes across three objectives

Grounding & Approach

The design opens by building awareness — an overview of what trauma does to the brain, supported by statistics and a short orienting video — before a **pre-survey** captures how confident learners currently feel handling distressed customers. This baseline both activates prior knowledge and provides a measurable point of comparison for the post-survey at the end.

Outcomes & the 3 R's framework.

Three measurable objectives carry learners from awareness, to communication, to applied de-escalation — each anchored in the 3 R's.

Learning Objectives

1

Identify

how trauma can influence customer behavior and responses — recognizing the signs of a stress or trauma response across channels.

2

Use

empathetic communication techniques to build trust and understanding with customers in distress.

3

Apply

de-escalation strategies to manage challenging interactions calmly and effectively.

The 3 R's Framework

The organizing model learners carry into every interaction.

R

RECOGNIZE

Notice the behavioral and verbal signs that a customer may be experiencing a stress or trauma response.

R

RESPOND

Stay calm and grounded, using empathetic language and tone to steady the interaction.

R

RESIST

Avoid actions and language that could re-traumatize, escalate, or shame the customer.

How the course *flows*.

Each objective becomes a module with its own teaching content, practice activity, and reflection — scaffolding learners from understanding to application.

Opening · Awareness & Baseline

~8 MIN

Build relevance and capture a confidence baseline before content begins.

- Overview of **what trauma can do to the brain** — the stress response and why customers behave as they do
- Animated **statistics** on trauma prevalence to establish relevance
- Short **overview video** framing the course
- **Pre-survey**: how confident do you feel dealing with distressed customers?

Module 1 · Recognize

~12 MIN

Objective 1 — Identify how trauma influences customer behavior.

- Teach the **3 R's framework**, with focus on recognizing signs
- **Slide presentation** on common trauma responses and how they appear in service settings
- **Role-play videos** modeling what recognition looks like in real interactions

Module 2 · Respond with Empathy

~14 MIN

Objective 2 — Use empathetic communication to build trust.

- **AI-simulated customer interactions** with short scripted dialogues to model empathetic language
- Small-group activity: build a **list of empathetic responses** to realistic case studies

Practice, then *prove* it.

The final module puts de-escalation into practice, and a layered assessment strategy confirms the learning held.

Module 3 · De-escalate

~16 MIN

Objective 3 — Apply de-escalation strategies effectively. This is the practice centerpiece.

- **Grounding exercises & breathing techniques** learners can use in the moment
- **Video scenarios** demonstrating de-escalation strategies and responses
- **Infographic** summarizing the de-escalation steps for quick reference
- Reflection prompt: *"What grounds me when a customer is upset?"*
- **Wordwall sharing** — learners contribute grounding strategies to a shared board

Assessment & Measurement

PRE & POST

Confidence surveys bookend the course — the pre-survey sets a baseline; the post-survey measures the shift in learner confidence handling distressed customers.

KNOWLEDGE

Matching activity reinforces understanding by pairing customer situations with the correct category of trauma-informed response.

REFLECTION

Personal grounding reflection and Wordwall contribution encourage transfer of de-escalation strategies to the learner's own role.

TERMINAL OUTCOME

By the end of the course, employees understand trauma's impact, communicate with empathy, and de-escalate challenging interactions effectively — turning moments of conflict into moments of trust.

Why it's built *this way*.

A short note on the instructional decisions behind the blueprint — the kind of thinking a hiring manager looks for.

AWARENESS BEFORE SKILLS

The course front-loads the brain science and statistics so learners understand *why* customers behave as they do before practicing *how* to respond. Understanding the cause builds genuine empathy rather than scripted politeness.

A MEMORABLE FRAMEWORK

The 3 R's — Recognize, Respond, Resist re-traumatization — give learners a simple, durable mental model they can recall under pressure, long after the course ends.

PRACTICE IN SAFE CONDITIONS

AI-simulated dialogues and video scenarios let learners rehearse emotionally-charged interactions without real-world stakes, lowering anxiety and increasing willingness to try new language.

PSYCHOLOGICAL SAFETY

Reflection prompts are framed around the learner's own coping ("*What grounds me?*") rather than forcing disclosure of personal trauma — keeping the experience supportive for learners who may have lived experience themselves.

MEASURED IMPACT

Pre- and post-confidence surveys make the soft skill measurable, while the matching assessment checks conceptual understanding — giving stakeholders evidence the training worked.

SOCIAL REINFORCEMENT

The Wordwall sharing activity turns individual reflection into collective wisdom, reinforcing strategies and building a shared team vocabulary around trauma-informed service.

Tools & Methods

PRE / POST SURVEYS

SLIDE PRESENTATION

ROLE-PLAY VIDEO

AI-SIMULATED DIALOGUE

INFOGRAPHIC

WORDWALL

REFLECTION PROMPTS

MATCHING ASSESSMENT